

The Intervention That Poisoned the Next One

Lesson 39 — Libya and Syria: divergent paths

What you will know and be able to do

1

Explain how Libya's uprising escalated into NATO-backed regime change

2

Explain why Syria's uprising followed an entirely different trajectory

3

Trace the direct, documented link between the two conflicts

4

Evaluate how far international intervention itself shapes a civil war's outcome

Two more countries, the same regional wave

Lesson 38 covered Tunisia and Egypt's relatively rapid, if incomplete, transitions. Libya and Syria, both entering the same wave of unrest within weeks, would follow trajectories almost unimaginably more violent — and, crucially, would shape each other directly.

From protest to armed revolt within days

Protests against Muammar Gaddafi's four-decade rule began in February 2011, met immediately with water cannons and live fire. Unlike Tunisia and Egypt, this repression escalated almost immediately into armed rebellion, with opposition forces seizing Benghazi and other eastern cities within weeks.

UN Resolution 1973, 17 March 2011

As Gaddafi's forces advanced back toward Benghazi, the UN Security Council authorised a no-fly zone and “all necessary measures” to protect civilians, passing 10 votes to 0 with five abstentions, including Russia and China, who chose not to veto rather than actively endorsing military action.

NATO's intervention

NATO forces began operations on 19 March, ultimately flying over 26,500 sorties across eight months, including 7,000 direct bombing missions against Gaddafi's forces — support that went well beyond simply protecting civilians, actively enabling rebel forces to capture Tripoli in August and hunt down Gaddafi himself, killed near Sirte that October.

Russia and China conclude they were deceived

Resolution 1973 had been framed and voted on as a narrow civilian-protection measure. Watching it become the vehicle for Gaddafi's forcible overthrow, Russia and China concluded they had been misled about NATO's actual intentions — a perception with direct, lasting consequences for the very next major crisis in the region.

March 2011: protest against a family dynasty

Protests erupted against Bashar al-Assad's government — ruling as part of a family dynasty stretching back to his father Hafez's 1971 seizure of power — initially organised, deliberately, as peaceful demonstrations modelled directly on Tunisia and Egypt's successful examples.

From peaceful protest to armed rebellion

Assad responded to protest with sustained, brutal military force rather than concession. As peaceful methods failed to produce Tunisia or Egypt's rapid results, some opposition figures began looking instead to Libya's armed model — by March 2012, the exiled Syrian National Council had formally endorsed the armed insurgency already underway on the ground.

Weapons, money, and inspiration flowing from Tripoli

The connection between these two conflicts was not merely thematic: post-Gaddafi Libya's new government made a documented \$100 million donation to Syrian rebels, and a regular supply of weapons moved from Libya through Turkey into Syria. Qatar's enthusiastic backing of Syrian rebels was itself inspired directly by its perceived success in Libya.

Why the Security Council response was so different

Having concluded they had been deceived over Libya's mandate, Russia and China vetoed every subsequent Security Council resolution that might have opened the door to comparable intervention in Syria — while Russia went further still, becoming Assad's direct military backer rather than a merely reluctant bystander.

Swift regime change, versus a war without end

Libya's conflict, however troubled its aftermath, resolved militarily within eight months. Syria's, denied any comparable international consensus and actively sustained by outside military support for Assad, became one of the twenty-first century's longest and most devastating civil wars — a direct consequence, in significant part, of how the previous year's Libyan intervention was perceived.

A fragmented country, even after Gaddafi's fall

Libya's post-Gaddafi Transitional National Council struggled to build a functioning state; rival militias refused to disarm, and the country slid into a second civil war from 2014, eventually dividing between a UN-recognised government and General Khalifa Haftar's rival forces — the latter backed by the UAE, Egypt, Saudi Arabia, and, from 2019, Russian mercenaries.

Syria's civil war, by the numbers

350,000+

Estimated deaths across the conflict

Over half

Share of Syria's pre-war population
displaced from their homes

2011–present

Duration, making it one of the century's
longest civil wars

The conflict produced what UN agencies described as the world's largest refugee crisis in decades.

Ghouta, 21 August 2013

A year after President Obama warned that chemical weapons use would cross a “red line” changing his calculus on intervention, a sarin gas attack on rebel-held Ghouta killed roughly 1,400 people, many of them children. Facing the choice of military strikes or a diplomatic alternative, Obama ultimately accepted a Russian-brokered deal for Syria to surrender its chemical arsenal — declining the military response many had expected.

The opening extremists exploited

Whatever the diplomatic deal's genuine successes — removing an estimated 90–95% of Syria's declared chemical stockpile without a single further shot fired — the decision not to strike Assad directly is widely seen as having opened space for extremist groups, including what would soon become ISIS, to expand by offering Syrian civilians the protection from Assad's forces that outside powers had just declined to provide themselves.

A full essay attempt

'International perceptions of the 2011 Libya intervention were the single most important factor shaping the Syrian civil war's trajectory.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position and evaluative criterion clearly
- Use specific evidence: the Resolution 1973 vote, and Russia and China's subsequent Syria vetoes
- Address the counter-argument that Syria's own internal conditions mattered independently of Libya

Key terms from today

UN Resolution 1973

Authorised Libya's no-fly zone and civilian protection, March 2011.

Syrian National Council

The exiled opposition body that endorsed armed struggle by March 2012.

Perceived mandate overreach

Russia and China's view that NATO exceeded its authorised mission in Libya.

Proxy dynamic

Outside powers backing opposing sides, prolonging rather than resolving conflict.

What to remember

Libya's rapid escalation into NATO-backed regime change and Syria's descent into prolonged civil war were not simply parallel, unrelated events — Russia and China's sense of having been deceived over Libya's mandate directly shaped their subsequent, comprehensive blocking of intervention in Syria, while Libyan weapons, money, and inspiration flowed directly into the Syrian conflict itself.

Lesson 40 — The rise of ISIS

Next lesson: how Syria's civil war, layered onto post-2003 Iraq's own instability, allowed a splinter of Al-Qaeda to seize territory across two countries and declare a self-styled caliphate.